How to See Opportunities Before Everyone Else

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📋 Executive Summary

Greg Lav takes viewers on a 48-hour convenience store expo trip, revealing Bloom Energy's 2027 growth pillars, the concept of marketing arbitrage, a near-death Amazon crisis, and raw reflections on entrepreneurship's real personal costs.

📑 Contents

- ✈️ Setting the Scene: Amazon Prime Day on a Plane
- 🏪 Bloom's Convenience Store Journey
- 🎯 2027 Growth Strategy: Convenience Stores + Clubs
- 🤝 The Expo: Pitching to Old-School Retailers
- 🌐 Networking at the Expo: Larry Wheels, Christian Guzman & Others
- 📈 Amazon Prime Day Rankings Obsession
- 💡 Marketing Arbitrage Explained
- 🚨 The Amazon Ban: Bloom's Near-Death Experience
- ☕ Ice Coffee Hour Appearance: Business, Money & Mindset
- 💸 Nine-Figure Day & The TD Bank Story
- 🧠 Personal Philosophy: What You Don't Want as a Mentor
- ✈️ Private Jet Ethics & Shareholder Responsibility
- 🦃 The Real Cost of Entrepreneurship: Lost Holidays

✈️ Setting the Scene: Amazon Prime Day on a Plane 0:25

- Greg is on a plane with no Wi-Fi heading to a convenience store expo during Amazon Prime Day
  - Describes it as losing his mind because he can't refresh Amazon rankings
  - On Prime Day he normally refreshes Amazon every 30 minutes, obsessing over rankings and sales
- Amazon has been organically leaning into Bloom
  - Bloom appeared on the Amazon homepage on Prime Day without paying for the placement
  - The reason: Amazon rewards brands that drive *external* traffic (from Instagram, TikTok) to Amazon, viewing those customers as more valuable than native Amazon shoppers
  - Estimated value of that homepage placement: **$600,000 for 24 hours**
    - Greg notes he bought the entire front page ~4 years ago for **$1.3 million**; today it would cost roughly **$1.8 million**

🏪 Bloom's Convenience Store Journey 1:34

- Bloom had never been in 7-Eleven, Circle K, Wawa, or Buc-ee's prior to this push
  - They were "slow out of the gate" in the convenience store channel
- Key structural challenge: most convenience stores are owned by franchisee owners
  - Even in chains like 7-Eleven, individual store owners have significant autonomy over merchandising
  - These owners are already making strong margins on Monster, Red Bull, Fritos, and Slurpees — no natural reason to take shelf space away
- Strategy to break in: grassroots chipping away
  - Sent customers into stores requesting Bloom by name: "Hey, I want Bloom. Why aren't you carrying Bloom?"
  - Proved sales organically before expecting placement
- After **18 months** of this effort, Bloom is now having "major success" in convenience stores
- Industry expert resistance:
  - Consultants said a **purple energy drink would never work in a convenience store** because the channel skews blue-collar working males, which is not Bloom's traditional demographic
  - Greg and team proved that thesis wrong

🎯 2027 Growth Strategy: Convenience Stores + Clubs 3:27

- Greg identifies two channels as the **biggest unlock for Bloom in 2027**:

Channel	Customer Profile	Purchase Behavior
Convenience Stores	Individual impulse buyer	Single cans from a cold fridge
Club Stores (Costco, Sam's Club)	Wealthy household mom shopping for family	18–24 cans at once

- These are two opposite ends of the spectrum but both represent massive growth opportunities
- The expo goal: shake 1,000 hands in 48 hours, make major deals, fly home

🤝 The Expo: Pitching to Old-School Retailers 3:50

- The core challenge Greg anticipates: convincing a 60-year-old gas station marketplace owner in Kansas who has never opened TikTok that Bloom belongs on his shelves
  - The pitch Greg has to make: "This purple energy drink will sell better than Red Bull, Monster, and Celsius in your store"
  - The expected pushback: "Red Bull and Monster have sold well for 10 years — why would I give up their shelf space?"
  - Greg will literally have to explain what social media is to some of these operators

- Key insight from a retailer Greg speaks with (owner of ~200 convenience stores):
  - Recent celebrity brand launches failed partly because reps were **arrogant and acted like they were doing retailers a favor**
  - The retailer's cousins turned those brands away outright
  - Advice: be **humble and authentic**; the retailer-brand relationship is a **symbiotic partnership**
    - "You need us, we need you" — families own these stores, just like Bloom is family-owned
- 7-Eleven meeting highlights:
  - Some speculation about whether a purple can would work in 7-Eleven — operator says "I want more purple, but only from Bloom"
  - Valentine's Day exclusive opportunity discussed: Bloom gets a full week highlighted, running the entire promotional period
    - Described as "cutting in front of the Coca-Colas and Pepsi Colas of the world" in terms of focus
    - Tied to a Centennial promotion; potential exclusive later in the year in P5
  - Operator emphasizes: energy drink category is crowded — **Bloom must communicate a differentiated emotional story**, not just product specs
    - "It targets another customer" is the key message
    - Bloom's team is asked to create sizzle reels and put their pitch guy Brandon in a costume to stand out in meetings

🌐 Networking at the Expo: Larry Wheels, Christian Guzman & Others 5:44

- **Larry Wheels** — powerlifter turned entrepreneur
  - Built PR Lifestyle, OneGen Gym, and brand partnerships
  - Started making content **15 years ago at age 17**, has been consistent since
  - Quote: "How you master yourself, you master the world"
- **Coconut water entrepreneur** — started on cruise ships, now on **150 ships**; quote: "When you leave with love, you always win"
- **Christian Guzman** — fitness YouTuber who built Alphaland and 3D Energy
  - Launched 3D Energy around 2016, crushed it for ~3 years
  - Around years 4–5, communication broke down with partners; he was in charge of marketing/can design/labor, partners handled all retailer relationships
  - Eventually couldn't get answers; tried to reclaim the company, ultimately got **100% equity back** amicably
  - Inherited **1.5 million cans of old inventory** and burned retailer relationships (ghosted by 3D)
  - Decision point: take the brand back or destroy/liquidate
    - Called Dom (first person who came to mind), sold through the 1.5M cans, used those funds to finance a rebrand
    - First full calendar year after rebrand: bigger than ever
  - Greg's summary: "A 9-year overnight success"

- Former federal inmate entrepreneur:
  - Federal prison number tattooed on arm; served ages 23–31 (now 48)
  - Committed to going straight upon release; started small in 7-Elevens
  - Learned business by listening to Bloom/Greg's content
  - Greg's reaction: "You have me very f***ing fired up right now"

📈 Amazon Prime Day Rankings Obsession 7:13

- Greg checks Amazon rankings from the expo floor
  - Last check: Bloom was #5, behind a brand called Bananas
  - Live refresh result: **Bloom climbs to #3**; Bananas drops to #12
  - Greg's reaction is visibly euphoric — describes this as "the arena"

💡 Marketing Arbitrage Explained 11:08

- **Definition of marketing arbitrage:** finding a white space of ultra low-cost impressions that no one has discovered yet, with first-mover advantage to saturate a tactic before the market catches on
- Historical examples from Bloom's evolution:
  - **Era 1 — Instagram meme pages (early chronological algorithm)**
    - Bought ads on meme pages telling people to follow Bari Llewellyn's Instagram
    - Almost no other brands were doing this; impressions cost **cents on the dollar**
    - People weren't yet desensitized to ads in their feed — everything felt authentic
  - **Era 2 — TikTok influencers (2019–2021)**
    - Paid influencers who had no agents and had never monetized their content
    - Built genuine economic relationships with creators
    - Got marketing for far less than any other available channel
  - **Era 3 — TikTok Shop (current)**
    - Current CPM on TikTok Shop: **under $2**
    - Compare to a hot podcast CPM: **$30–$75**
    - Greg calls this "full-on arbitrage"
- The underlying marketing trend — value migrates down the follower ladder:
  - Starts with celebrities → big Instagram influencers → 1M follower accounts → 250K follower accounts (perceived as more authentic) → eventually down to the **singular individual**
  - TikTok Shop democratized the individual creator layer
  - Implication for brands: you can't just work with 20 influencers anymore — **you need to work with thousands**
- Metaphor for absorbing advice before you're ready:

- When entering a new venture, listen to veterans even if their advice goes over your head — nod, shut up, absorb what you can
- As you move through the venture and unlock new areas, you'll recall the advice at the exact moment it becomes relevant
- "Save this video and come back to it later" — the point of the whole segment

🚨 The Amazon Ban: Bloom's Near-Death Experience 20:50

- In his mid-20s, Greg got distracted by what he calls "Miami boys" — day traders, growth hackers, Amazon manipulators making quick money
  - Started chasing growth hacks instead of focusing on product quality and authentic content
- Hired an agency to run Amazon growth initiatives without properly overseeing their methods
  - Agency bought **fake reviews** on Bloom's Amazon account without Greg's knowledge
  - Result: **Bloom was kicked off Amazon for 45–60 days**
- Consequences of the ban:
  - Described as "by far the most stressful 45 days" of his career
  - **Were approximately 24 hours away from massive layoffs**
  - "Everything would have gone under"
- Key lesson: never outsource oversight of tactics that could violate platform rules; growth hacks are a distraction from building real product quality

☕ Ice Coffee Hour Appearance: Business, Money & Mindset 17:44

- After the two-day expo trip, Greg appears on the **Ice Coffee Hour podcast**
- Topics covered: money, business, personal branding
- Is it easier than ever to make a million dollars?
  - Greg: **"The arena doors are wide open."**
  - Opportunities have been democratized regardless of circumstances
  - Counterintuitively: "shittier circumstances" = bigger upside in 2026
  - Legacy brands and corporations **need** new young entrepreneurs more than ever
  - Consumers are actively asking for new products and are tired of boring legacy brands not catering to their needs
  - Verdict: **Yes, it is easier than ever to make a million dollars**
- On his perpetual high energy:
  - It wasn't always this way — there were years with no motivation, nothing working, being the only one clapping for himself
  - Had to drag himself out of bed and refuse to let mood or emotions dictate his actions
  - Once winning started: "it becomes like this limitless energy pill"
  - The feeling of winning — even without dollar signs — is "the most addicting and best feeling in the world"

- Blind energy drink taste test (5 cups, unlabeled):
  - Correctly identifies Celsius immediately ("major medicinal aftertaste")
  - Correctly identifies Red Bull by smell alone ("I don't even need to sip it" — citrus orange)
  - C4 ends up as his second favorite
  - **Bloom is his favorite**
- On what entrepreneurship feels like:
  - "Playing GTA in real life" — even if unpaid, he'd still play the game
  - A 14-hour day of NYC lunch meetings, supplier talks, beverage tastings = "an awesome day"
  - Contrasts with the Gary Vee-era "grind" image of sitting in a white closet on a laptop all day

💸 Nine-Figure Day & The TD Bank Story 19:17

- Greg and his wife sold a piece of Bloom in an enterprise value transaction
  - Received **$100 million+ (nine figures)** via **four wire transfers in a 24-hour period**
  - Opened a brand new bank account specifically for it
- Origin story — the TD Bank era:
  - Started selling booty bands on Instagram while in college using a **TD Bank student account**
  - Would instruct PayPal to transfer money daily, then go to TD Bank and **withdraw all the cash**
  - Stored the cash in the **car glove box**
  - TD Bank eventually flagged the account and asked if he was a drug dealer — then **kicked them out**
  - Greg and Mari then decided to form an LLC and open a business bank account at Chase
    - Mari walked in and put **$40,000 cash on the counter** — all the cash from the glove box
    - That business was called **Mari Fitness** (which later evolved into Sleigh, then into Bloom)

🧠 Personal Philosophy: What You Don't Want as a Mentor 22:26

- Greg did not have traditional role models to look up to
  - Instead, he learned more from **what he didn't want to become** than from aspirational figures
- Framework: constantly build a list of what you *don't* want
  - It is easier to articulate what you don't want than what you do want (especially in your 20s)
  - Example: observing himself spending 2 hours with his son every morning before work and saying "that sounds like a pretty good dad to me"
  - He externalizes actions into objective sentences and evaluates them: would I respect this? Is this what I don't want?
- On Christian Guzman — admires that despite grueling building phase (working 2 a.m.–dawn because his Lebanon-based design team was 8 hours ahead, bleeding **$220K/month** just for the Alphaland property without renovations, doing two-day work benders, barely sleeping), Christian kept his wife Heidi through it all

    - Greg and Christian both identify as introverts who recharge at home — neither likes going out
    - Greg: "My energy is at home with my family and Leo. I just go everywhere with Leo."
- Observation about entrepreneurial prime:
    - Greg assumed everyone hit their prime in their 20s because that's what he watched
    - Now meeting **35–45-year-olds** who are hitting the peak of their careers and are in the best physical shape of their lives
    - Also seeing 18–19-year-olds on "generational runs" due to current opportunities
    - Takeaway: lock in on diet and routine → become the person capable of handling big goals
        - "You can hit your goals, but you'll fall down to your systems"

✈️ Private Jet Ethics & Shareholder Responsibility 25:16

- Greg spends an estimated **$500K+ per year on private jets** (possibly more when chartering is included)
- He deliberately does **not** write off flights as a business expense — even though he could
    - Reasoning: private jets are a luxury, not a true necessity for Bloom's growth
    - If team members have stock options in Bloom and that money is being spent on his personal jet preference instead of on community events or brand growth, he views that as a **disservice to his shareholders**

        > "I think that would be a disservice to my shareholders. I have enough money. I'm able to keep the lights on for sure."
- Reflects a broader philosophy: personal wealth and business expenses should remain clearly separated when the team has equity stakes

🦃 The Real Cost of Entrepreneurship: Lost Holidays 26:02

- Greg did not attend Thanksgiving **for 5 consecutive years** or Christmas **for 5 consecutive years** during Bloom's building phase
- When he finally had a son and decided he wanted large family gatherings, he called his mom and siblings to restart the traditions
    - His mom's response: **"Greg, we don't do Thanksgiving anymore. You never came, so we stopped that tradition."**
    - Christmas: same answer — they had each built their own individual holiday traditions in his absence
    - As one of only two kids in the family, his absence eliminated the family gathering entirely
- Describes this as "a bit of a reality hit of some of the real sacrifice of what entrepreneurship is"
- Current goal: building a larger, beautiful family gathering — that is what he is "going for now"
- Closes with: still committed to being "the biggest savage I can possibly be in the arena of consumer packaged goods"